🌿 Spiritual Deconstruction & Reclamation
Self-Guided Study Syllabus

Overview
This course is a structured exploration of faith deconstruction, religious trauma recovery, mysticism, sacred embodiment, and spiritual reconstruction. It is designed for people raised in Christianity who feel like key truths were hidden, distorted, or weaponized—and who are ready to rebuild something real.

Structure
- **Modules:** 8 Core + 4 Bonus
- **Pacing:** 1 module every 7–10 days (or slower)
- **Daily Time Commitment:** 30–60 minutes
- **Practice Focus:** Embodied, reflective, symbol-rich learning
- **Outcome:** A fully personalized, integrated, living theology

🧱 Module 1: Christianity & Power
Theme: Evangelicalism, Christian nationalism, purity culture
Read:
- *Jesus and John Wayne* – Du Mez
- *Taking America Back for God* – Whitehead & Perry

Watch:
- "Jesus and John Wayne Talk" – Kristin Du Mez
- "What is Christian Nationalism?" – The New Yorker

Practice:
- Journal: What was I taught about America + God?
- Watch for the symbols of nationalism in old sermons or songs

🌸 Module 2: Sacred Feminine & Rebalancing
Theme: Divine feminine, Mary Magdalene, body-based divinity
Read:
- *The Meaning of Mary Magdalene* – Bourgeault
- *Dance of the Dissident Daughter* – Kidd

Watch:
- "Cynthia Bourgeault on the Gospel of Mary"
- "Return of the Sacred Feminine – Llewellyn Vaughan-Lee"

Practice:
- Rewrite a prayer to the feminine divine
- Create a sacred feminine altar

🌀 Module 3: Deconstructing the God-Image
Theme: Ego, false self, control-based theology

Read:

- *Falling Upward* – Rohr
- *The Power of Now* – Tolle

Watch:

- "Richard Rohr – True Self / False Self"
- "Rob Bell – God is Not a Man with a Beard"

Practice:

- Stillness meditation with the mantra "I am not my thoughts"
- Journal: What did God look like when I was five?

🧠 Module 4: Religious Trauma & Healing

Theme: Nervous system recovery, somatic release, trauma-informed presence

Read:

- *The Wisdom of Your Body* – McBride
- *The Body Keeps the Score* – van der Kolk

Watch:

- "Religious Trauma in the Body – Therapy in a Nutshell"
- "Returning to Your Body – Hillary McBride"

Practice:

- Daily grounding ritual (barefoot, hand to chest)
- Track trauma triggers in spiritual spaces

🌌 Module 5: Mysticism & the Sacred Unknown

Theme: Symbol, paradox, nonduality, contemplative awareness

Read:

- *The Naked Now* – Rohr
- *New Seeds of Contemplation* – Merton

Watch:

- "What is Christian Mysticism?"
- "Rob Bell – The Language of the Soul"

Practice:

- 10-min silence with sacred word: Light, Mercy, Here
- Create a "symbol dictionary" from dreams, images, memories

🕊️ Module 6: Personal Theology & Inner Authority

Theme: Post-belief spirituality, permission, creative faith

Read:

- *You Are Your Own* – Jamie Lee Finch
- *Do I Stay Christian?* – Brian McLaren

Watch:

- "You Are Your Own Authority – Jamie Lee Finch"
- "Theology Without a Net – Peter Rollins"

Practice:

- Write your own belief statement or spiritual manifesto
- Speak your truth out loud—even if alone

🍄 Bonus 1: Psychedelics & Mystical States

Theme: Healing, ego dissolution, direct experience
Read:

- *How to Change Your Mind* – Pollan
- *The Immortality Key* – Muraresku

Watch:

- "Johns Hopkins Psychedelic Studies"

Practice:

- Journal: What truths might only emerge when I surrender?

✨ Bonus 2: Reclaiming Ritual & Prayer

Theme: Non-religious sacred habits
Read:

- *Everything is Spiritual* – Rob Bell

Watch:

- "Barbara Brown Taylor – Finding God Beyond Church"

Practice:

- Create one intuitive ritual (candle, breath, mantra)

🧭 Bonus 3: Daily Practice Design

Theme: Sacred rhythm, Rule of Life
Read:

- *Sacred Rhythms* – Barton (optional)

Watch:

- "Jack Kornfield – Daily Practice"

Practice:

- Create a sustainable rhythm with 1–2 daily anchor points

🛡️ Bonus 4: Talking to Christians Who Don't Understand

Theme: Boundaries, communication, emotional safety
Read:

- "You Don't Have to Explain Yourself – Medium"

Watch:

- "Therapy in a Nutshell – Boundaries with Religious Family"

Practice:

- Draft 3 boundary phrases you can use in real life

✍️ Weekly Reflection Template

- What did I read, watch, or practice this week?
- What do I now know that I didn’t before?
- What is changing in me—emotionally, mentally, or spiritually?
- What sacred truth did I reclaim?

Spiritual Deconstruction & Healing Journey

A 16-Week Guided Syllabus for Reclaiming Your Authentic Spirituality

Foundation: Before You Begin

Essential Preparation (Week 0)

Create Your Sacred Container:

- Set up a private journal (physical or digital) dedicated to this journey
- Establish a quiet, safe physical space for reading/reflection
- Identify 2-3 trusted people who can support you (friends, therapist, spiritual director)
- Create a simple daily grounding practice (5-10 minutes of breathing, movement, or meditation)

Protective Boundaries:

- Decide who you will/won't discuss this journey with
- Prepare simple responses for intrusive questions: "I'm exploring some spiritual questions right now" or "I'm taking time to reflect on my faith"
- Set limits on religious content consumption (news, social media, family discussions)

Phase 1: Stabilization & Awareness (Weeks 1-4)

Week 1-2: Religious Trauma & Body Awareness

Primary Reading:

- *The Wisdom of Your Body* - Hillary McBride (Chapters 1-5)
- Begin *The Body Keeps the Score* - Bessel van der Kolk (Introduction + Chapter 1)

Daily Practice (15-20 minutes):

- Morning: 5 minutes of conscious breathing
- Evening: Body scan meditation (notice tension, numbness, or discomfort)
- Journal prompt: "What does my body remember about church/faith that my mind has forgotten?"

Weekly Check-in:

- What physical sensations arise when you think about your religious upbringing?
- Where in your body do you feel safe? Unsafe?
- What spiritual practices feel nurturing vs. triggering?

Week 3-4: Naming What You're Leaving

Primary Reading:

- *Jesus and John Wayne* - Kristin Du Mez (Chapters 1-4)
- Listen to 2-3 episodes of "Straight White American Jesus" podcast

Daily Practice:

- Morning: Grounding breathwork
- Evening: Write one belief you inherited vs. one truth you're discovering
- Weekly: Create a "Letting Go" list - write down beliefs/practices that no longer serve you

Weekly Check-in:

- What aspects of your faith background do you want to release?
- What fears arise when you imagine letting go?
- How does your body respond to naming these truths?

Phase 2: Deepening Understanding (Weeks 5-8)

Week 5-6: Power Structures & Historical Context

Primary Reading:

- Complete *Jesus and John Wayne*
- Begin *Taking America Back for God* - Whitehead & Perry (Chapters 1-3)

Daily Practice:

- Morning: Grounding + intention setting
- Midday: Micro-check-in with your body (Am I tense? Overwhelmed? Curious?)
- Evening: Journal on power dynamics you experienced in religious settings

Weekly Check-in:

- How do you feel about the intersection of politics and your religious upbringing?
- What patterns of control or authority do you recognize?
- Where do you feel anger? Grief? Relief?

Week 7-8: Sacred Feminine & Embodied Divinity

Primary Reading:

- *Dance of the Dissident Daughter* - Sue Monk Kidd (Chapters 1-6)

- *The Meaning of Mary Magdalene* - Cynthia Bourgeault (Chapters 1-3)

Daily Practice:

- Morning: Movement meditation (gentle stretching, dancing, walking)
- Evening: Light a candle and sit in silence for 5-10 minutes
- Weekly: Create a simple altar or sacred space with objects that feel meaningful

Weekly Check-in:

- How does it feel to consider the divine as feminine or beyond gender?
- What aspects of your body/sexuality/femininity were shamed in religious settings?
- What would change if you believed your body was sacred rather than sinful?

Phase 3: Mystical Awakening (Weeks 9-12)

Week 9-10: Contemplative Prayer & Nondual Awareness

Primary Reading:

- *The Naked Now* - Richard Rohr (Chapters 1-8)
- *New Seeds of Contemplation* - Thomas Merton (Chapters 1-5)

Daily Practice:

- Morning: 10-15 minutes of silent sitting/contemplative prayer
- Throughout day: Practice "sacred pauses" - brief moments of presence
- Evening: Journal on experiences of presence, peace, or connection

Weekly Check-in:

- How does silent prayer differ from the prayer you learned growing up?
- What happens when you let go of words and just be present?
- Where do you sense the divine most clearly?

Week 11-12: Mystical Experience & Integration

Primary Reading:

- *Being Aware of Being Aware* - Rupert Spira (Chapters 1-4)
- Listen to talks by Cynthia Bourgeault or Adyashanti

Daily Practice:

- Morning: Awareness meditation (simply noticing what's here)
- Evening: Reflective writing on moments of connection or insight
- Weekly: Spend time in nature as spiritual practice

Weekly Check-in:

- How has your understanding of God/divine/sacred evolved?
- What experiences of unity or connection have you noticed?
- How do you want to nurture this emerging spirituality?

Phase 4: Reconstruction & Integration (Weeks 13-16)

Week 13-14: Personal Theology & Inner Authority

Primary Reading:

- *You Are Your Own* - Jamie Lee Finch
- *Do I Stay Christian?* - Brian McLaren (Chapters 1-6)

Daily Practice:

- Morning: Read your evolving personal creed/values list
- Midday: Practice trusting your inner knowing in small decisions
- Evening: Write about what spirituality means to you now

Weekly Check-in:

- What beliefs feel true and life-giving to you now?
- How do you want to practice spirituality going forward?
- What would your ideal spiritual community look like?

Week 15-16: Boundaries & Sustainable Practice

Primary Reading:

- *Set Boundaries, Find Peace* - Nedra Glover Tawwab (Chapters 4-8)
- *Sacred Rhythms* - Ruth Haley Barton (Chapters 1-4)

Daily Practice:

- Morning: Commit to your chosen spiritual practices
- Throughout day: Practice saying "no" to what doesn't align with your values
- Evening: Reflect on how you maintained your boundaries and energy

Weekly Check-in:

- How will you handle religious holidays/family gatherings?
- What spiritual practices do you want to continue?
- How will you protect your peace while staying connected to others?

Daily Structure & Rhythms

Morning Ritual (10-15 minutes)

1. **Grounding:** 5 minutes of breathwork or body awareness
2. **Intention:** Read your current learning focus or personal values
3. **Practice:** Engage with your current spiritual practice (prayer, meditation, movement)

Evening Reflection (15-20 minutes)

1. **Integration:** Journal on the day's reading or insights
2. **Body Check:** Notice what you're carrying physically/emotionally
3. **Gratitude:** Name 2-3 things you're grateful for in your journey

Weekly Sabbath (2-3 hours)

- Take a complete break from deconstructive reading/thinking
- Engage in pure joy: nature, creativity, friendship, rest
- Let your soul breathe without analyzing or processing

Warning Signs & Self-Care Protocols

Red Flags - Pause and Seek Support:

- Persistent insomnia or nightmares
- Panic attacks or severe anxiety
- Complete loss of meaning or hope
- Suicidal thoughts or self-harm impulses
- Inability to function in daily life
- Excessive isolation or withdrawal

When Overwhelmed:

1. **Stop reading** - Take a 2-3 day break
2. **Return to your body** - Bath, walk, gentle movement
3. **Connect with support** - Call a trusted friend or therapist
4. **Practice grounding** - 5-4-3-2-1 technique (5 things you see, 4 things you hear, etc.)
5. **Remind yourself:** "This is temporary. I am safe. I am not alone."

Monthly Milestones & Celebrations

Month 1: "I am learning to trust my body and my experience"

Celebrate: Create something beautiful (art, poem, playlist) that represents your journey so far

Month 2: "I can name what I'm leaving and what I'm choosing"

Celebrate: Share one insight with a trusted friend or write yourself an encouraging letter

Month 3: "I am discovering new ways to connect with the sacred"

Celebrate: Design a personal ritual or ceremony to honor your growth

Month 4: "I am becoming my own spiritual authority"

Celebrate: Write your personal manifesto or spiritual mission statement

Resources for Ongoing Support

Crisis Resources:

- National Suicide Prevention Lifeline: 988
- Crisis Text Line: Text HOME to 741741
- Religious Trauma Syndrome Support Groups (Facebook, Discord)

Community & Connection:

- r/Deconstruction (Reddit)
- The Liturgists Community
- Progressive Christian/Post-Christian Facebook groups
- Local UU congregations or contemplative communities

Professional Support:

- Psychology Today therapist finder (filter for religious trauma)
- Spiritual directors through Spiritual Directors International
- EMDR or somatic therapists for trauma processing

Remember Always:

This journey is not linear. You will have breakthrough days and setback days. Both are part of the process.

Your pace is perfect. If you need to slow down, repeat a week, or take breaks, honor that wisdom.

You are not alone. Millions of people have walked this path. Your story matters and your healing is possible.

Trust your inner knowing. You have everything you need within you to discern truth from manipulation, love from control, and authentic spirituality from performative religion.

Your body is wise. When something feels heavy, constraining, or fear-based, listen to that wisdom. When something feels expansive, peaceful, or life-giving, lean into it.

You are already whole. This journey is not about becoming something new—it's about remembering who you've always been beneath the layers of others' expectations and fears.

"The cave you fear to enter holds the treasure you seek." - Joseph Campbell

Begin when you feel ready. Trust the process. Honor your pace. You've got this.